

What's in a name?

FROM MYTHOLOGY

- Since it was first discovered not on Earth but in the Sun, **helium** was named after the ancient Greek Sun god **Helios**.
- The highly radioactive metal **promethium** is named after **Prometheus**, the ancient Greek hero who stole fire from the gods.
- The precious metal **palladium** was named after the asteroid Pallas, which itself was named after the ancient Greek goddess **Pallas Athena**.
- Because it produces many colourful chemicals, the metal **iridium** was named after **Iris**, the ancient Greek goddess of rainbows.
- **Titanium** is a strong, silvery metal, and was named after the **Titans**, a group of powerful deities who battled the Olympian gods in ancient Greek mythology.
- The metal **tantalum** was named after the mythical figure **Tantalus**, who was punished by the ancient Greek gods by being put in a pool of water that he was never able to drink from.
- Because of its similarity to tantalum, **niobium** was named after **Niobe**, the daughter of Tantalus in ancient Greek mythology.
- **Vanadium** is a corrosion-resistant metal named after the Scandinavian goddess Freyja, whose Norse name is "**Vanadis**".

REFLECTING COLOURS

- **Chlorine** was named after the Greek word "**chloros**", meaning "**greenish yellow**", to describe the colour of the pure gas.
- **Caesium's** name comes from the Latin word "**caesius**", meaning "**sky-blue**" – the metal produces blue flames when it burns.
- The element **indium** was named after the colour **indigo**. The metal's atoms give off a dark-blue light when they are electrified.
- **Rubidium** gets its name from the Latin word "**rubidus**", meaning "**deepest red**", referring to the metal's flames when burned.
- The metal **chromium** was named after the Greek word "**chroma**", which means "**colour**". Its compounds have many different shades.
- The mineral orpiment, which is the main ore of **arsenic**, is yellow in colour. The element gets its name from the Greek word "**arsenikon**", meaning "**yellow orpiment**".